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Culture as Catalyst: A Strategic Framework for Mental Well-Being in High-Stress Energy Workplace

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According to the World Health Organisation (WHO), mental health is "a state of mental well-being that enables people to cope with the stresses of life, to realize their abilities, to learn well and work well, and to contribute to their communities." WHO emphasizes that mental health is more than just the absence of mental disorders; it is an integral component of overall health that influences how individuals think, feel, relate to others, and function in society.

Mental health exists along a spectrum, can fluctuate with life circumstances, and is shaped by a wide range of individual, social, and structural factors. Fluctuations in mental health throughout our lives are normal, but it is the recovery from the fall, which is the crucial phase where support required for any individual, matters. Timely access to appropriate support and interventions significantly increases the likelihood of recovery from mental ill health.

The rapid evolution of the global workplace has brought mental health and well-being to the forefront at the workplace as well, with workers today facing enhanced levels of stress, burnout, and psychological fatigue — conditions that can lead to decreased productivity, disengagement, and long-term health impairments.

Introduction

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fatigue — conditions that can lead to decreased productivity, disengagement, and long-term health impairments.

Relevance to the Energy Sector

Mental health has emerged as a core determinant of workforce resilience, productivity, and safety, especially in high-risk, high-pressure industries such as oil and energy. In these sectors, employees often grapple with operational demands, physical hazards, long working hours, and remote locations, all of which intensify stress, fatigue, and emotional strain. Traditionally, occupational health and safety frameworks have focused more on physical risks. However, the equally critical domain of mental health has not received the same depth of attention. According to the World Health Organization (2022), depression and anxiety alone cost the global economy an estimated US \$1 trillion each year in lost productivity.

The mental health of workers in the oil and gas sector remains a critical yet often overlooked and underreported occupational risk. Mental health of workers is defined by WHO as "a state of mental well-being that enables people to cope with the stresses of life, to realize their abilities, to learn well and work well, and to contribute to their community." This definition emphasizes not only the ability to manage daily pressures and stresses but also the capacity for personal growth, productive work, and meaningful contributions within the workplace. According to the WHO, work can be both a protective factor and a potential risk for mental health. Safe, supportive, and inclusive workplaces promote well-being, while poor working conditions such as excessive workloads, discrimination, job insecurity, and lack of support pose significant risks to mental health. A worker's mental health is reflected in their social, emotional, and physical state. Protecting and promoting mental health at work involves preventing work-related risks, fostering supportive cultures, enabling help-seeking, and supporting workers with mental health conditions to fully participate and thrive at work.

In industrial sectors such as oil, gas, and energy, these concerns are further amplified due to unique operational challenges, including high-risk environments, unpredictable scheduling, remote or offshore locations, and exposure to environmental hazards. The workforce in this sector, often engaged in high-pressure decision-making and physical labour under demanding conditions, faces added psychological stressors not commonly experienced in standard corporate settings. Furthermore, a predominantly masculine work culture and legacy systems often inhibit open conversations around vulnerability and mental health support.

Problem Statement

Despite the growing availability of worldwide best practices for workplace mental health, the energy industry does not yet have a tailored, sector-specific framework that guides how businesses should systematically advance psychological safety and well-being. Current approaches, including health training or passive Employee Assistance Programs (EAPs), are often fragmented, reactive, or unduly general, and tend to overlook structural drivers of occupational stress. Furthermore, the growing and changing expectations of different generations are often overlooked. As a result, even the best mental health policies are underutilized, misunderstood, or seen as mere checkboxes.

Although the energy sector has traditionally focused on physical health and safety procedures, the importance of mental health and wellness for total employee well-being and business success is becoming increasingly apparent in recent days.

Although both are crucial issues in their own right, mental health and wellness are closely related to and have a significant impact on the successful application of physical health and safety procedures. Moving ahead from the present disjointed approach, organisations can promote a more comprehensive and long-term strategy for developing a resilient and productive workforce by giving mental health as much priority as physical safety measures.

Research Objectives

There is a growing volume of literature on mental well-being in the general workforce, but relatively little focuses on the operational, leadership, and cultural complexities of the energy sector, emphasising the need for inclusion of a structured framework integrated for addressing mental health issues of the workforce in the energy sector, with a predominant cultural shift. This study is an attempt to address how organizations can transition from reactive to proactive approaches, or benchmark their own maturity based on a structured approach in addressing mental health challenges with Culture as a catalyst.

This paper aims to contribute towards providing a road map to the energy sector by:

- Analyzing current challenges faced by workers in the energy sector related to mental health and well-being through a detailed study.
- Reviewing best practices and evidence-based models from other high-risk industries.
- Introducing a novel Organisational Mental Health Maturity Model (OMHMM), a tailored framework for energy organisations.
- Outlining scalable interventions that integrate psychological safety into business performance metrics and leadership accountability.

This paper puts forward a culture-first framework specifically designed for the energy sector. It starts with the belief that mental health is not a peripheral concern to be managed occasionally, but a central component of operational excellence and long-term sustainability. By reframing mental well-being as a collective leadership responsibility, this paper seeks to provide a thoughtful, scalable, and human-centered model for creating supportive and resilient workplaces across the energy value chain.

Significance of the Study

This work underscores the business and human rationale for embedding mental well-being into the strategic goals of energy sector organisations. By offering a structured framework, the manuscript aims to empower leaders, HR professionals, and HSE officers to not only respond to mental health challenges but also actively cultivate resilient, engaged, and psychologically safe work environments. The OMHMM introduced here presents a scalable roadmap that organisations can use to assess their current level and identify pathways for continuous improvement.

As the sector evolves amidst digitalization, generational shifts, and energy transition imperatives, organizations that prioritize psychological well-being will be better positioned to attract talent, ensure safe operations, and deliver sustainable impact.

Literature review

The Business Case for Mental Health in Energy Workplaces

Recent research by the McKinsey Health Institute highlights a growing disconnect between employer intentions and employee experiences when it comes to mental health support. There is a striking disconnect: while over seventy percent of employers think they are meeting mental health needs at work, fewer than one in three employees agree. This gap is especially concerning in high-stress sectors such as oil and gas, where the intensity of operations often leaves little room for softer, culture-oriented aspects of employee care.

A 2024 report from the Boston Consulting Group further reinforces this point by showing how psychological safety functions as more than just a moral obligation. It is, in fact, a strategic advantage. In hazardous and team-based environments like offshore rigs, refineries, and logistics centers, psychological safety can help reduce burnout, encourage innovation, and promote collaboration. A study published in ScienceDirect in 2025 supports this by linking strong organizational support systems to reduced burnout,

particularly in energy settings where extended rosters and remote operations frequently contribute to mental fatigue.

Stigma, Silence, and the Failure of Reactive Interventions

According to McKinsey's work on stigma, one of the biggest barriers to mental health progress is silence. In many workplaces, particularly in male-dominated and hierarchical industries such as oil and gas, employees are reluctant to speak up about psychological challenges. Employee assistance programs, while widely available, are often underutilized because they feel disconnected from the day-to-day experience of teams. They are perceived as reactive rather than preventive, and many workers fear that disclosing mental health concerns could jeopardize their careers.

An article by Simon Lee Maryan on LinkedIn (2024) offers a candid view from within the sector, explaining how presenteeism, geographic isolation, and a high-pressure work culture discourage even basic conversations about mental health. When workers are physically isolated, such as on rigs or in remote marketing territories, and emotionally unsupported, they become more vulnerable to burnout and disengagement. This creates a cycle of silence and deterioration that is difficult to break.

Generational Shifts and Rising Expectations

The demographic composition of the workforce is changing, and so are expectations. Younger employees, particularly those from the Millennial and Gen Z cohorts, are more likely to expect workplaces to be empathetic, transparent, and actively supportive of mental health. They are also more open to acknowledging and seeking help for psychological challenges. According to McKinsey's national survey from 2023, younger workers report mental health symptoms more frequently and are more likely to leave jobs if they feel unsupported. In a sector where retaining skilled talent is critical, addressing mental health is not just an act of care; it is a competitive necessity.

Sectoral Evidence from Energy, Oil & Gas

Scientific studies provide essential insights into the energy sector's unique mental health landscape. A research paper titled "The Analysis of the Effect of Mental Workload and Burnout on Employees' Safety Behaviour in the Oil and Gas Industry Using Roster Systems" clearly shows that extended shifts contribute directly to burnout, which in turn compromises safety performance. Another study from ScienceDirect in 2025 explains how fatigue acts as a mediator between physical isolation and unsafe behaviour, reinforcing the need to consider mental health as part of overall safety planning.

The IADC North Sea report further echoes these findings by highlighting mental health as a critical safety issue. It recommends moving beyond policy statements and toward a more engaged leadership model that fosters openness, empathy, and cultural transformation. Taken together, the research makes one thing clear: mental health cannot be separated from operational strategy. It must be integrated into the systems, values, and everyday behaviours that define the workplace experience.

Workers in the oil and gas sector encounter considerable mental health challenges arising from the distinctive and highly demanding conditions of their work environment. Due to the inherent demographics and work culture of the oil and gas sector, employees are particularly vulnerable to chronic fatigue, which in turn has a pronounced impact on their mental well-being. Sector-specific stressors play a devastating role in complicating and enhancing the impact of Mental health across workers in the energy sector.

- **Remote and Isolated Work Sites:** Many oil and gas employees work in remote areas, such as offshore rigs or distant drilling fields, often for weeks at a time. This physical isolation from family and familiar surroundings leads to loneliness, strained personal relationships, and reduced social support, which can heighten the risk of depression and anxiety.
- **Long, Rotational, and Demanding Shifts:** The sector is notorious for long and irregular hours, with 12-hour shifts and multi-day rotations being common. Such schedules disrupt normal

sleep patterns, cause chronic fatigue, and impair both physical and mental well-being. Workers consistently report experiencing poorer sleep quality and more frequent disturbances during shifts compared to when they are at home.

- **High-Risk and High-Responsibility Work:** Employees are tasked with critical, high-stakes operations where errors can lead to severe safety incidents, environmental harm, or even fatalities. The constant pressure to avoid mistakes and maintain vigilance adds to chronic stress, fostering anxiety and burnout.
- **Stigma Around Mental Health:** There is a persistent cultural stigma in the oil and gas industry regarding mental health discussions. Employees often fear being perceived as weak or unfit if they report psychological distress, leading to underreporting and a reluctance to seek help.
- **Harsh and Hazardous Physical Environment:** Many employees endure difficult weather, small and basic living conditions, and hard, physically exhausting work. Exposure to hazardous situations can also lead to trauma and, in some cases, post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD).
- **Substance Use and Risk Behaviours:** Studies show that oil and gas workers are more likely to engage in risky behaviours, including excessive alcohol and tobacco consumption. These may be used as coping mechanisms for stress, isolation, and fatigue, but can worsen mental health issues.
- **Economic Instability and Job Insecurity:** Volatile oil prices, layoffs, and cyclical employment patterns breed financial uncertainty, further adding to workers' anxiety and emotional strain.
- **Inadequate Support Systems:** Despite progress, mental health support in the sector often lags behind that for physical health. Nothing or a fragmented approach in terms of occasional counselling, poor management practices, and limited resources for mental health exacerbate employee stress and psychological distress.

Common mental health disorders linked to the unique environment in oil and gas include depression, anxiety, substance abuse, and PTSD. The prevalence of anxiety and depression is notably higher than in the general population, with at least 19-26% of incapacity claims in the sector being mental-health-related.

Addressing these challenges requires not only stronger stigma reduction and improved on-site psychological support, but a cultural shift towards treating mental well-being with the same seriousness as physical safety. McKinsey's framework for "operationalizing mental health" emphasizes that without a clear strategy, structured behaviors, and accessible tools, well-being programs become perfunctory exercises—what they call "well-being theater". Proactive approaches—such as flexible shift patterns, access to mental health professionals, and supportive management—are critical for mitigating the unique psychological risks in this industry.

Methodology

The study encompassed a **mixed-method exploratory design**, integrating primary quantitative data collected from the oil & gas workforce across global organisations with an extensive secondary literature review.

Study Design

The primary research component involved a cross-sectional, organization-wide work stress assessment, conducted across multiple oil and gas companies with diverse operational setups. The objective was to capture the harmful work stress, depression, NCDs like cardiovascular disease, hypertension, and diabetes, along with selected lifestyle risk factors, including tobacco use, alcohol use, and overweight/obesity.

A cross-sectional e-assessment was conducted on a random sample of 1000 employees across multiple oil and gas companies situated globally. The sample covered representation from across geographic zones, business functions, and hierarchical levels, spanning junior-level to senior management across onshore and offshore locations.

The demographic variables considered for the study included age, gender, years of service, position level, role type, relationship status, number of dependents, and work location.

Tools

Two psychometrically validated tools were deployed for data collection – TAWS-16 and PHQ-9. TAWS-16 was deployed to identify workplace stressors across five dimensions: **role overload, career stagnation, organizational support, work-life balance, and managerial behaviour**. A cumulative score of ≥ 48 was considered indicative of work stress, further classified into mild (48–59), moderate (60–73), and severe (>73). The tool also measured physical and psychological symptoms such as sleep disturbances, irritability, headaches, and absenteeism, etc., with scores ≥ 36 denoted high risk. The PHQ-9, a self-administered screening instrument, was employed to assess both the presence and severity of depressive symptoms. The tool captures symptom severity over the past two weeks for 9 items aligned with the Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders, 4th edition (DSM-IV). The PHQ-9 total score ranges from 0 to 27 (scores of 5–9 is classified as mild depression; 10–14 as moderate depression; 15–19 as moderately severe depression; ≥ 20 as severe depression).

Data Analysis

Quantitative analysis was conducted using:

- Descriptive statistics to assess prevalence rates of stress and depression.
- Correlation analysis to determine associations between job role, age, health risk factors, and stress levels.
- Multivariate logistic regression to identify significant predictors of work stress and depressive symptoms.
- Cross-tabulation to examine departmental trends and risk concentration.

Demographic and lifestyle risk variables (e.g., tobacco/alcohol use, obesity, chronic illness) were tested for their influence on stress scores. Comparative analysis across roles (field vs. administrative) provided insights into structural inequities in mental health exposure.

Secondary Research

To contextualize and validate the findings, this study conducted a detailed review of global best practices and peer-reviewed evidence from agencies such as:

- World Health Organization (WHO, 2022)
- American Psychological Association (APA, 2024)
- National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health (NIOSH)
- McKinsey Health Institute (MHI, 2023)
- Boston Consulting Group (BCG, 2024)
- Mental Health America (MHA)
- Benenden Health (2021) – Workplace wellbeing report: mental health trends in UK industries
- Dräger Safety Research (2019–2022) – Personnel Health and Safety in Energy Operations
- Amy Edmondson – Psychological Safety and the Learning Organization
- Maslach & Leiter – The Burnout Challenge

- International Labour Organization – Safe and healthy work environments
- IADC North Sea

These references helped identify benchmark metrics for psychological safety, mental health maturity, and leadership accountability, providing a comparative lens for interpreting primary data.

Limitations

While comprehensive, the study has the following limitations:

- **Cross-sectional nature:** Data represent a single time-point and may not capture seasonal or post-crisis fluctuations.
- **Self-reporting bias:** Despite anonymity, some underreporting of psychological distress may persist due to internalized stigma.
- **Limited qualitative insights:** The study focuses on numeric assessments; deeper ethnographic understanding was beyond the scope.

Results/Findings

Data of 1000 participants, aged 20-60 years, were analysed to estimate the prevalence of work stress, depression, NCDs and NCD risk factors. More than three fourths of the employees were males (88.7%) and were married (79.5%). The majority (63.5%) of the individuals participating in this study were aged between 20 - 40 years and 45.6% were having less than 10 years of work experience. One fourth of the employees assessed had a service duration of more than 20 years.

Prevalence and Intensity of Work Stress

- 15.1% of employees reported work stress, with 8.2% mild, 4.6% moderate, and 2.3% severe.
- The median stress score for those experiencing stress was 58 out of 96. Severe stress cases had a median of 80.
- Employees in junior management, offshore operations, and field roles exhibited significantly higher levels of stress than their administrative or senior management counterparts.

Key Work Stressors Identified

- Time/deadline pressure: 27.3%
- Extended work hours: 26.3%
- Multitasking and role ambiguity: 23.8%
- Limited involvement in decision-making: 23.1%
- Lack of promotion opportunities: 22.1%
- Poor work-life balance: 21.1%

Risk Factor Correlations

- Employees aged 31–40 were 25% more likely to report work stress than younger peers, while those aged above 50 had a 75% lower risk.
- Male employees had 51% lower odds of reporting stress compared to females.
- Employees screening positive for depression were 23 times more likely to report work stress.

- The presence of NCDs or risk factors (alcohol, tobacco, obesity) significantly increased stress levels:
 - Tobacco use: 93% higher odds of stress
 - Alcohol use: 51% higher odds
 - Cardiovascular disease: over 100% higher odds

Depression and Psychological Distress

- 15.9% screened positive for depression. Among them, 44% exhibited moderately severe to severe symptoms.
- Prevalence was higher in business functions, field staff, and younger employees, particularly those in junior or mid-level management.
- The highest rates were reported in sectors requiring constant exposure to risk, rotational shifts, and limited support systems, such as offshore rigs and refinery operations.

Non-Communicable Disease (NCD)

- 83.8% of employees had at least one NCD risk factor.
- 36.4% reported alcohol use, 35.7% were overweight/obese, and 14% used tobacco.
- 41.7% had one or more diagnosed NCDs (including hypertension, diabetes, and cardiovascular conditions).
- Employees in high-intensity zones reported the highest combined prevalence of stress and physical comorbidities.

Departmental & Role-Based Insights

- Employees in field operations had twice the prevalence of stress compared to administrative staff.
- Leadership roles were associated with reduced stress, whereas individual contributors without decision-making authority showed elevated distress.

Discussion

The findings from the industry-wide work stress assessment clearly indicate that mental health challenges in the oil and gas sector are not incidental but deeply embedded in the structure, pace, and expectations of work. Employees across functions whether in offshore rigs, operations, or refinery reported high levels of stress, emotional exhaustion, and symptoms of clinical depression. Importantly, the factors contributing to this distress were not random; they clustered consistently around five domains: workload, ambiguity, autonomy, recognition, and interpersonal environment.

These stressors are not simply operational constraints—they are reflections of deeper cultural patterns within organizations. For example, role overload and time pressure signal a culture of relentless urgency, often reinforced by leadership behavior. Lack of promotion opportunities and limited involvement in decisions reflect cultures where hierarchy overrides meritocracy and participation. Similarly, poor work-life balance and inconsistent managerial empathy point to an environment where human sustainability is not considered central to productivity.

The assessment data showed that even when mental health resources were available, their utilization remained low. This aligns with APA and McKinsey research, which reveal a consistent pattern: where organizational culture lacks psychological safety, employees do not feel safe to use the very resources

designed to support them. In this context, introducing isolated solutions such as mental health webinars, helplines, or resilience workshops fails to address the root of the problem. These interventions, while helpful in intent, often function like band-aids on structural wounds.

Failures of isolated interventions

Efforts to manage employee mental health in silos—separated from organizational systems, leadership commitment, and cultural norms—tend to fail for several reasons:

- **Superficial or Short-Lived Impact:** One-off training sessions, limited awareness campaigns, or scattered access to Employee Assistance Programs (EAPs) can create only temporary boosts in awareness but rarely lead to sustained behavioural change or improved well-being.
- **Failure to Address Underlying Causes:** Mental health concerns in oil and gas stem from systemic and environmental factors, such as remote work, high stress, stigma, and hazardous conditions. Interventions that don't address shift patterns, management culture, job security, and peer support rarely reduce anxiety and stress long-term.
- **Lack of Cultural Change:** Bringing real improvement requires shifting workplace culture to destigmatize mental health discussions and genuinely value mental well-being as much as physical safety. Isolated programs do not challenge the deep-rooted norms and resistance that cause people to hide struggles or avoid seeking help.
- **Poor Uptake and Engagement:** When interventions are implemented as an add-on—rather than woven into daily processes—employees may not feel encouraged or safe to participate. Stigma, scepticism, and concerns about confidentiality further reduce engagement.
- **Insufficient Support Systems:** Without ongoing support from leadership, middle management, and peer networks, isolated interventions fail to provide the continued encouragement and practical assistance employees need. Training fades without reinforcement and follow-up.
- **No Measurable Outcomes:** Fragmented, one-time interventions are rarely evaluated for effectiveness, making it hard to identify what works and what doesn't. Without real data and continuous improvement, there's little return on investment, and problems persist.
- **Fragmented Care Models:** Over-reliance on external or isolated services (like referring only to outside therapists) ignores the power of community, peer support, and inclusion in daily work life. Sustainable improvements are seen when mental health becomes an ongoing, integrated component of safety, human resources, and leadership strategies.

Leadership and Culture as Catalysts for Psychological Safety

Leadership and cultural change are critical in shaping psychological safety at the workplace—a foundational element for employee well-being, innovation, and high team performance.

- **Setting the Tone:** Leaders set the behavioral standard for teams. Their actions define whether it's safe to speak up, admit mistakes, or challenge the status quo. If leaders model openness, humility, and acceptance of diverse views, employees feel empowered to share concerns, propose bold ideas, and learn from failures.
- **Role Modeling and Vulnerability:** When leaders show vulnerability and admit their own challenges or mistakes, it legitimizes open conversations throughout the team. This transparency fosters trust and encourages employees to take interpersonal risks without fear of humiliation or retribution.
- **Fostering Collaboration:** Leaders who practice consultative and supportive leadership—seeking opinions, valuing input, and supporting individuals as people—drive the creation of a positive team climate, which is consistently shown to elevate psychological safety.

- Encouraging Learning from Failure: By framing mistakes as learning opportunities rather than occasions for blame, leaders support a growth mindset and encourage experimentation, leading to improved morale and organizational performance.

Importance of Cultural Change

- Embedding Safety in Culture: Genuine psychological safety cannot rely solely on isolated interventions; it must be woven into the organization's culture, influencing "the way we do things around here." This requires consistent practices, visible leadership commitment, and collective buy-in at all levels.
- Norms and Shared Values: Organizations with cultures that prioritize mutual respect, transparent communication, and inclusion see much higher levels of psychological safety. These norms should be reflected in policies, performance metrics, and leadership evaluations.
- Sustainable Transformation: Cultural change is not a one-time event; rather, it's an ongoing process of aligning organizational behaviors, recognition systems, and communication practices with the goal of making psychological safety a lived value.

Best Practices for Leaders and Organizations

- Prioritize and Talk About Psychological Safety: Make it a clear, explicit priority connected to organizational goals like innovation, engagement, and safety.
- Facilitate Speaking Up: Encourage every voice, honor openness, and frame candid conversations as essential, not risky.
- Redesign Responses to Failure: De-stigmatize mistakes and treat them as vital parts of learning, not as reasons for punishment.
- Continuous Feedback and Inclusion: Give and ask for feedback constructively, engage in inclusive decision-making, and acknowledge all contributions openly.
- Align Systems for Reinforcement: Use metrics, incentives, and recognition systems to reward behaviors that support psychological safety and cultural change.

Impact

When leadership and culture are aligned to support psychological safety, organizations report:

- Increased team performance and engagement
- Higher levels of creativity and innovation
- Greater resilience in times of change
- Improved employee well-being and retention

In summary, leaders play an indispensable role in modeling, reinforcing, and embedding psychological safety through their behavior, communication, and decisions—while broad cultural change ensures these efforts have lasting, organization-wide impact. Empowering all levels of the workforce to speak openly, ask for support, and contribute to a more psychologically safe environment. Addressing these intertwined challenges is essential to protect worker well-being and ensure a safe, sustainable oil and gas industry.

Framework Proposal

Proposed Occupational Mental Health Maturity Model for the Oil & Gas industry outlines a progressive framework to help organizations and support them to be proactive than to be reactive to address employee

mental well-being. It is the result of synthesizing insights from several internationally recognized models, including:

- WHO's "Protect, Promote, Support" workplace mental health approach
- ISO 45003, Guidelines on managing psychosocial risks
- The Job Demand-Resources (JD-R) Model
- The PERMA (Positive Emotion, Engagement, Relationships, Meaning, Accomplishment) model of well-being by Martin Seligman
- Amy Edmondson's Psychological Safety research
- UK's Thriving at Work Review (Farmer-Stevenson Report)

Proposed Model

Level 1: Reactive and Fragmented. At this foundational stage, mental health is perceived largely as a personal issue rather than an organizational responsibility. Companies may respond to mental health crises when they arise but lack any structured approach or preventive measures. There is minimal or no investment in mental health resources, and support, if available, is often uncoordinated or informal. Conversations around emotional well-being are typically stigmatized or avoided altogether, especially in traditionally masculine and high-risk work cultures like oil and gas. Leadership engagement is absent, and mental health is rarely discussed in strategic or operational planning. Employees struggling with stress or burnout often suffer in silence, which increases the risk of disengagement, safety incidents, and attrition.

This stage aligns with the "Unaware" phase described in WHO and ILO's mental health continuum models, where interventions are sparse and reactive, and culture reinforces silence rather than support.

Level 2: Aware but underprepared. Organizations in this phase begin to acknowledge mental health as a workplace issue and often implement basic programs as part of compliance or social responsibility initiatives. This typically includes Employee Assistance Programs (EAPs), general awareness webinars, and wellness days. While these are important first steps, they tend to be surface-level, generic, and underutilized. Mental health remains primarily the domain of the Human Resources department, with little accountability among operational leaders. Stigma persists due to a lack of genuine leadership modeling and a culture that continues to prioritize physical safety over psychological safety.

Companies at this level often adopt frameworks like ISO 45003 or WHO's Protect-Prevent-Promote model but treat them as external standards rather than embedding them into core practices. Training is one-off and not reinforced. Feedback mechanisms are limited, and employee trust in these programs remains low.

Level 3: Structured and Integrated. At this maturity level, organizations move from awareness to intentional integration of mental well-being into their systems and practices. Leadership begins to take visible ownership of mental health outcomes, and efforts become cross-functional—extending beyond HR to include operations, safety, and line management. KPIs related to psychological safety, absenteeism, and employee engagement are tracked, and interventions are designed based on data from surveys, culture audits, and risk assessments.

Managers are trained to recognize early signs of distress and engage in safe, constructive conversations. Mental health support is woven into core business practices such as shift scheduling, onboarding, performance reviews, and safety briefings. Peer support programs, internal mental health champions, and storytelling initiatives help normalize mental health dialogues.

This stage draws upon elements of Amy Edmondson's Psychological Safety framework, McKinsey's operationalizing mental health model, and the CDC's integrated mental health strategy. It reflects a shift

toward preventative infrastructure, where mental health is recognized as both a workforce risk and a performance enabler.

Level 4: Inclusive and Culture-Centered. At this advanced stage, mental health is treated as a strategic business priority, embedded within the organization's culture and reflected in its leadership philosophy, communication style, and operational rhythm. Mental well-being is no longer discussed only in times of crisis, it is a visible, routine aspect of work life. Leadership consistently models empathy and psychological openness, making it safe for employees to express vulnerability and seek support.

Cultural audits and pulse surveys are conducted regularly, and data-driven insights inform decision-making across teams. Teams actively co-create well-being initiatives, and peer networks are empowered to lead grassroots programs. The organization adopts inclusive practices that recognize intersectional experiences, accommodating mental health needs across age, gender, role, and geography.

This level reflects the most evolved elements of frameworks such as the Mental Health Continuum Model (Canada), the BCG Psychological Safety model, and McKinsey's Health Equity approach. Organizations operating at this level report stronger retention, higher innovation scores, and lower incident rates, as psychological safety becomes both a human and business differentiator.

Level 5: Embodied, Adaptive, and Future-Ready. The final maturity stage represents a truly transformed organizational culture—where mental health is not just a policy or program, but an embedded, living principle that shapes every aspect of work. Here, mental well-being is part of the organizational DNA, upheld through shared values, collective rituals, leadership development, and strategic planning.

The organization not only sustains what has been built but evolves it continuously through feedback loops, external benchmarking, and real-time employee engagement systems. Mental health becomes central to the employer brand, contributing to competitive advantage in talent attraction, investor trust, and long-term sustainability.

Adaptive capabilities ensure the organization responds proactively to emerging challenges such as AI-induced stress, intergenerational tensions, geopolitical uncertainties, and environmental risks. This stage is marked by full integration of mental health into ESG strategies, business continuity plans, and stakeholder communications.

Organizations here often act as sector leaders, contributing back to the ecosystem through research, collaboration, and advocacy—setting new standards for the future of work.

Strategic Pillars Across All Levels

Each level of maturity is supported by three continuous strategic pillars, with culture forming the core.

Prevent Harm: Reduce Psychosocial Risk. This pillar focuses on proactively identifying and reducing systemic stressors that threaten mental health. Instead of treating stress as an individual problem, this approach recognizes it as a symptom of organizational design and culture. Key actions include:

- **Psychosocial Risk Audits:** Conduct structured assessments using tools like ISO 45003 guidelines to identify organizational sources of harm such as unclear job roles, unsafe workloads, or toxic leadership. These risks are then tied to team-level metrics.
- **Job Demands-Resources (JD-R) Mapping:** Analyze job profiles to balance demands (e.g., time pressure, travel) with adequate resources (e.g., autonomy, feedback, peer support). This helps prevent chronic burnout, especially in field and offshore roles.
- **Safe Scheduling Practices:** Introduce rotation systems and rest periods that prioritize recovery, especially in offshore or shift-based contexts where fatigue is a leading cause of burnout.
- **Integrating Mental Safety in HSE:** Make psychosocial safety part of the organization's Health, Safety, and Environment (HSE) framework, including risk registers and training programs.

- **Real-time Monitoring Tools:** Use digital dashboards or fatigue-tracking wearables to monitor stress levels among high-risk teams and intervene proactively.

Protect and Promote Mental Well-Being. The second pillar focuses on creating an environment that fosters emotional well-being and actively promotes mental health as a shared value. This pillar includes:

- **Leadership Training in Mental Health Literacy:** Equip managers and supervisors with tools to recognize early signs of stress, hold supportive conversations, and model healthy behaviors.
- **Mental Health Champions and Peer Allies:** Establish peer-led networks and Employee Resource Groups (ERGs) that can listen without judgment, guide towards resources, and advocate internally.
- **Visible Storytelling from Leaders:** Encourage senior executives to share their own well-being journeys or struggles, which helps break the culture of silence and normalize help-seeking.
- **Frequent Mental Health Campaigns:** Organize theme-based awareness weeks, webinars, and interactive sessions to sustain engagement around topics like emotional resilience, work-life harmony, and burnout prevention.
- **Pulse Surveys and Listening Channels:** Conduct regular anonymous feedback surveys to track psychological safety, belonging, and stress levels - segmented by teams, gender, and geography.
- **Inclusive and Flexible Work Design:** Redesign roles to include flexibility for caregivers, ergonomic improvements, autonomy in task execution, and recognition mechanisms aligned with mental well-being.

Support Employees with Mental Health Conditions. Support goes beyond reactive care — it's about creating equitable systems for recovery, reintegration, and sustained success for those facing mental health issues. This includes:

- **Confidential and Accessible Care Pathways:** Establish clear, stigma-free access to mental health professionals, either on-site or via secure virtual platforms, with 24/7 availability where required.
- **Tailored Workplace Accommodations:** Customize job expectations, schedules, or physical spaces for employees recovering from burnout, depression, or trauma, especially relevant in physically demanding roles.
- **Structured Reintegration Programs:** Design 'return-to-work' pathways that include check-ins, reduced workload ramp-up, and peer mentorship after a mental health leave.
- **Guided Conversations for Managers:** Develop playbooks and decision trees for managers on how to respond when an employee discloses mental distress — rooted in empathy, not evaluation.
- **Peer-Led Recovery Circles:** Enable voluntary groups for employees to share recovery experiences, coping strategies, or simply find safe spaces for listening.
- **Zero-Retaliation Policies:** Codify organizational stance against discrimination due to mental health disclosures, with accountability mechanisms and escalation pathways.

The Core: Organizational Culture. What sets OMHMM apart is its emphasis on organizational culture as the linchpin. Culture defines whether employees feel safe, whether managers act empathetically, and whether resources are accessed without fear.

At every maturity level, the OMHMM embeds:

- **Leadership KPIs** include psychological safety, inclusion, and well-being metrics
- **Quarterly Culture Audits** monitor openness, empathy, and shared accountability
- **Cross-functional ownership:** Mental health is not delegated to HR - operations, safety, and commercial leaders are jointly accountable

- Tie to Business Outcomes: Track improvements in productivity, attrition, safety incidents, and engagement as culture improves

Adaptability Across Energy Sector Functions

The OMHMM is designed for contextual flexibility across the energy sector.

- In offshore rigs, emphasize prevention and support through fatigue reduction, isolation mitigation, and psychological first aid
- In refineries, focus on psychological safety in shift transitions, crisis response, and trauma-informed leadership
- In marketing and field operations, prioritize travel fatigue mitigation, digital well-being nudges, and mobile access to care
- In corporate offices, amplify culture-building, pulse surveys, and recognition-based protection strategies

Each domain within the energy sector has unique pressures — the OMHMM provides a roadmap that adapts to these while retaining its core philosophy.

Table 1—Culture first Occupational Mental Health Maturity model for Oil & Gas industries

Level	Description of organisation's present dealing of mental health situation	Focus on Pillars	Pillars of Maturity model			Level of maturity
			Preventing Harm	Promoting Mental Well-being	Support employees with mental health conditions	
Level 1: Reactive and Fragmented	Mental health is not formally addressed. Awareness and action are low.	No structured efforts; ad-hoc responses to crises.	Poor	Poor	Poor	Level I
Level 2: Aware but underprepared	Organization begins recognizing psychosocial risks and the importance of mental health.	Early efforts to prevent harm; limited or informal well-being promotion.	Fair	Fair	Poor	Level II
Level 3: Structured and Integrated.	Policies emerge for reducing risk and promoting well-being. Some support for mental health conditions.	Structured actions for preventing harm and protecting/ promoting well-being; basic support systems.	Good	Good	Fair	Level III
Level 4: Inclusive and Culture-Centered	Mental health is integrated into organizational practices and culture. Supports all three pillars.	Active promotion, formal policies to support employees with mental health conditions.	Very Good	Very Good	Good	Level IV
Level 5: Embodied, Adaptive, and Future-Ready	Mental health is a strategic priority and a core element of organizational resilience and culture.	Deeply embedded prevention, promotion, and support; continuous improvement and role modelling.	Excellent	Excellent	Excellent	Level V

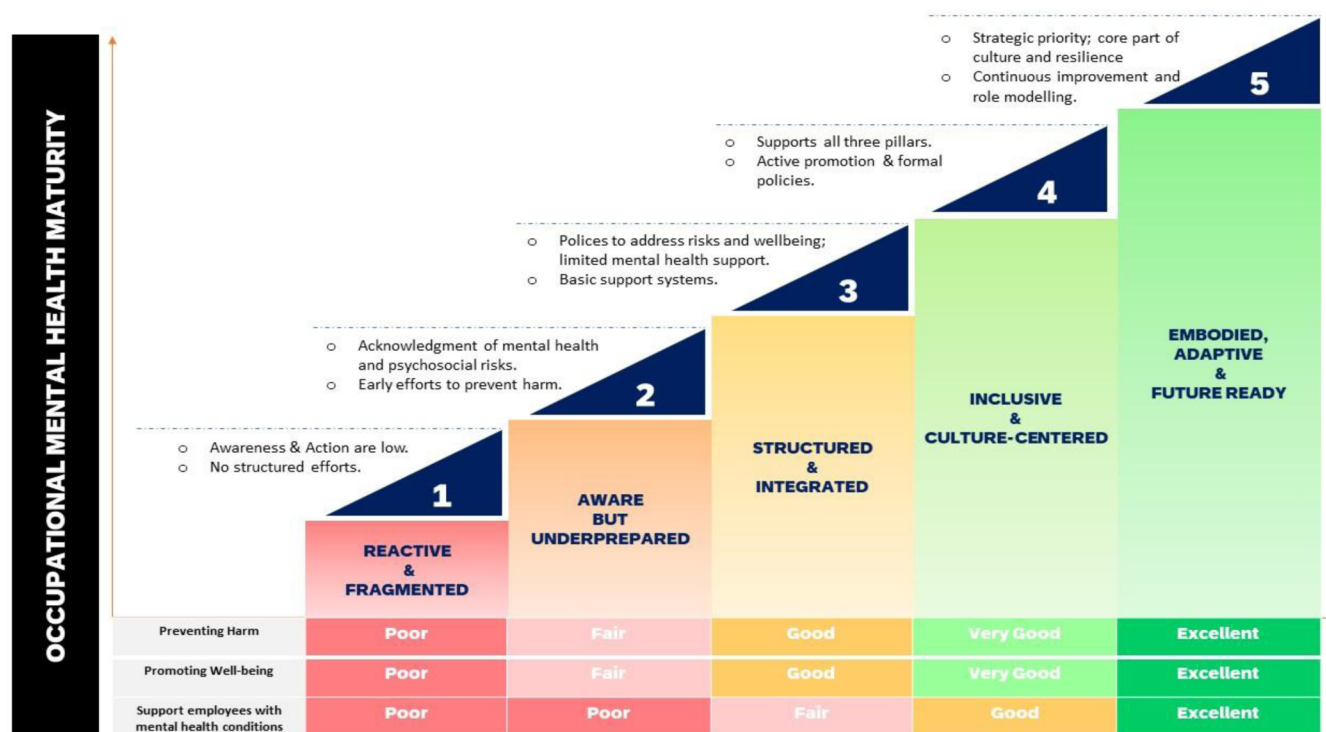


Figure 1—Occupational Mental Health Maturity Model

Conclusion & Future work

For companies in the oil, petroleum, and broader energy industries including those managing offshore platforms, long-haul distribution networks, and isolated refineries mental health is far more than a wellness initiative. It is a strategic priority with direct implications for performance, safety, and employee retention. The mental health crisis in industrial workplaces has only deepened in recent years due to the lingering impact of the COVID-19 pandemic, rising expectations from younger generations, isolation in remote work sites, and persistent workplace cultures that still stigmatize emotional vulnerability. Addressing mental health in these complex settings requires more than temporary fixes or benefit-driven solutions. It demands a deeper cultural shift, one that places employee well-being at the heart of how organizations operate and lead.

Findings from the study made across various Oil & Gas organisations across the world, show a similar trend, emphasising the critical and immediate need for embedding Occupational Mental Health as one of the pillars that an organisational culture is based on. Organisations moving towards Strategic It is imperative that holistic inclusion in organisational strategy will reap positive impact and contribute towards addressing mental health situations.

To be effective, mental health efforts in oil and gas must move from isolated, one-off interventions to sustained, organization-wide approaches that include cultural change, strong leadership support, integrated support systems, ongoing education, and real measurement of outcomes. Only then can the sector address its unique and deeply embedded mental health challenges.